

That's Nice! The Journey Of A Word

[B1]

Dal latino all'inglese moderno, la parola 'nice' ne ha fatta di strada! Ed è strano pensare che questo aggettivo, oggi usato per indicare qualcosa di piacevole, sia nato come un insulto.



The word 'nice' has a surprising history and it's a perfect example of how words can dramatically change meaning over time. Today we use 'nice' to mean that something or someone is 'pleasant', 'attractive', 'pretty' or '[kind](#)', but its original meanings weren't [flattering at all](#).

NOT KNOWING

It all began with the Latin word 'nescius', which means 'ignorant', '[unaware](#)', 'not knowing'. It comes from 'ne' ('not') and 'scire' ('to know'); which is the same [root](#) for the word 'science' and many related words such as 'conscience', 'prescient', and 'omniscient'! When nescius passed into Old French as nice, it kept the negative meaning: it described an [unaware](#), ignorant, [senseless](#) person: someone who 'didn't know'.

NEUTRALISATION

The word entered the English language with the Norman Conquest in 1066; the Anglo-Norman nice is documented from as early as 1212. For more than a century, the word was used to describe a 'stupid', 'ignorant', '[foolish](#)' or 'frivolous' person. From [the late 1300s](#), a more neutral sense of the word began to emerge: it characterised someone who was 'scrupulous', '[finely dressed](#)', 'very precise' or '[fussy](#)', even a person, [behaviour](#) or style of clothing considered 'excessively elegant and luxurious or sensual'.

HOW DO YOU SAY...?

No more Mr. Nice Guy. Ora basta fare il bravo!

AN EXPLOSION OF MEANINGS

But by the 15th century, the [range](#) of meanings had multiplied: 'nice' could mean '[wanton](#)' or 'lascivious', 'cowardly', 'extravagant', 'lazy', 'fragile' or 'demanding close attention'. In many texts from the 16th and 17th centuries, it is even difficult to determine which sense the writer intended. However, as the centuries went by, nice started to be used to describe something 'delicate', 'precise', 'refined' or 'cultured', all of them qualities associated with respectability and virtue, not just with a person's [looks](#). The word gradually lost its negative sense and [took on](#) a more neutral or even positive connotation; what was once an insult became a [compliment](#). Indeed, a very nice example of how language is a constantly changing phenomenon!

IT DOES FOR EVERYTHING

Finally, between the 18th and 19th centuries, ‘nice’ acquired a meaning very close to the one we know today. In fact, there is a passage in Jane Austen’s novel *Northanger Abbey* (1817) in which the author [mocks](#) this newly-fashionable term, with its acquired positive meaning, and especially its [overuse](#): “And this is a very nice day, and we are taking a very nice walk, and you are two very nice young ladies. Oh, it is a very nice word, [indeed](#)! [It does for everything](#). [...] now every [commendation](#) on every subject is [comprised](#) in that one word.”

Glossary

- **flattering** = lusinghiero
- **at all** = per niente, affatto
- **root** = radice
- **the late 1300s** = fine del XIV secolo
- **looks** = aspetto
- **compliment** = complimento
- **It does for everything** = va bene per tutto
- **commendation** = elogio
- **kind** = gentile
- **unaware** = inconsapevole
- **foolish** = sciocco
- **fussy** = esigente
- **range** = gamma, varietà
- **wanton** = dissoluto
- **finely dressed** = elegante, ben vestito
- **took on** = acquisire
- **mocks** = burlarsi
- **overuse** = abuso
- **comprised** = comprendere
- **senseless** = insensata
- **behaviour** = comportamento
- **indeed** = davvero